

From Current Workflow to Field Workflow

Assignment

OBJECTIVE

You have now defined your NGO context, primary user, specific problem, required capabilities, constraints, and an initial understanding of the current workflow. Your next step is to understand how the user's work changes when your proposed solution becomes part of it.

The Three Workflows

CURRENT → PROPOSED → POTENTIAL FIELD

Map the user's journey at three levels. The purpose is not to design the complete application; it is to understand how your core technology fits into the user's real-world workflow.

1. Current User Workflow

Start with the workflow you identified in the previous class. Describe what your primary user actually does today in the NGO context to accomplish the task related to your problem.

Helpful questions to ask yourself:

What triggers the workflow? • What does the user do? • What information or inputs do they use? • What decisions do they make? • Who else is involved? • What tools, documents, or systems are currently used? • What is the outcome of the workflow?

Deliverable:

Create one workflow diagram showing the current process from beginning to end. Where possible, distinguish between what is known from the NGO/context and assumptions that still need validation.

2. Proposed User Workflow

Now introduce your proposed solution into the same workflow. Do not create an entirely new workflow. Take the current workflow and show where and how your solution changes it.

Helpful questions to ask yourself:

Where does your solution enter? • What does the user provide to the solution? • What does the technology do? • What output does it produce? • What does the user do with that output? • Which existing steps change? • Which steps become easier, faster, or more reliable? • Are any new steps introduced?

Deliverable:

Create one workflow diagram showing the current process with your proposed solution integrated into it. Clearly highlight the part of the workflow that your team is proposing to change. Your proposed workflow should reflect the 2–3 capabilities you identified in the previous class. Show where each capability is used in the workflow.

Note: Your workflow should make this relationship clear: User Input → Core Technology → Technology Output → User Action.

3. Potential Field Workflow

Now look beyond the semester POC. Imagine that your core technology has been successfully developed and is sufficiently reliable for actual use in the NGO's field operations. How could the user's workflow operate then?

Helpful questions to ask yourself:

Who would actually use the technology? • Where would they use it? • When and how frequently would they use it? • What inputs would be required? • What happens when the technology produces its output? • Who acts on the output? • What happens if the technology fails or cannot produce a result? • What other people, systems, or processes would need to interact with it? • What would need to change within the NGO for this workflow to become possible?

Deliverable:

Create one potential field workflow showing how the solution could operate as part of the NGO's real-world work.

Note: This is not a request to design the entire production system. The purpose is to understand the operational context in which your core technology would eventually be used.

4. Compare the Three Workflows

Identify what actually changes as you move from the current process to your proposed solution and then to potential field deployment.

Deliverable:

Compare your three workflows along the following parameters:

	Current	Proposed	Potential Field
Primary user			
Key task			
Main input			
Role of technology			
Main output			
User action after output			
People / systems involved			
Important constraint			

Based on your comparison table, what is the most important change your solution introduces to the user's workflow? Explain in 2–3 sentences.

5. Questions / Assumptions to Validate

Identify 3–5 important assumptions in your workflows that you still need to validate. These may be validated through further investigation, interaction with the NGO/user, or through building and testing your solution.

Deliverable:

List 3–5 things that you have assumed and still need to validate in the user workflows you have drawn.

Submission

The following are to be included in your submission:

1. Current User Workflow
2. Proposed User Workflow
3. Potential Field Workflow
4. Three-workflow comparison
5. 3–5 assumptions / questions to validate

IMPORTANT NOTE

Start with the current workflow. Your proposed workflow should show how your solution changes that existing process. Your potential field workflow should show how that changed process could realistically operate if the technology were deployed in the NGO.

A GOOD WORKFLOW IS:

- Specific to your primary user.
- Grounded in the NGO context.
- Clear about inputs, decisions and outputs.
- Explicit about where technology enters.
- Clear about what the user does with the technology's output.
- Honest about assumptions.